The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Afghanistan launched “large-scale offensive operations” along its border with **Pakistan.** The Taliban said the strikes were in retaliation against Pakistani attacks on Afghanistan on Sunday. Pakistan said those strikes targeted groups responsible for several deadly attacks on its territory, including a suicide-bombing in Islamabad, the capital, that killed at least 36 people.

The average **30-year-mortgage rate** in America fell below 6% for the first time since 2022. Borrowing costs have been gradually declining since the middle of 2025. Inflation has slowed, and the Federal Reserve cut interest rates three times in the second half of last year. Lower mortgage rates could heat up America’s housing market, although their recent drop has not spurred home-buying.

Nuclear negotiations between **America** and **Iran** concluded in Geneva. Abbas Araghchi, Iran’s foreign minister, described them as one of the “most serious” yet. Badr Albusaidi, his Omani counterpart who was mediating the talks, said “significant progress” was made. Further discussions are expected to take place next week. Donald Trump has suggested America will attack Iran if it does not negotiate a deal.

A **German** court suspended the domestic spy agency's designation of **Alternative for Germany (AfD)** as an "extremist" organisation. The temporary ruling will allow the court to consider the hard-right party's appeal. The decision prevents authorities from keeping the party under targeted surveillance for now—a boon for the AfD ahead of upcoming state elections.

Borge Brende, the chief executive of the **World Economic Forum**, which organises the Davos meetings, resigned after it launched an investigation into his ties to Jeffrey Epstein. Files released by America's Justice Department suggested that Mr Brende, a Norwegian, attended dinners with him. He has denied knowledge of Epstein's crimes. Several business leaders have stepped down over similar links to Epstein.

A court in **Bangladesh** ordered the government to ask Interpol to issue a "red notice" against **Tulip Siddiq**, a British MP. The notice is a call for international assistance in her arrest. Bangladesh accuses Ms Siddiq of using her ties to her aunt—Sheikh Hasina, Bangladesh's autocratic former prime minister—to influence a real-estate deal. Ms Siddiq denies wrongdoing and Britain does not have an extradition treaty with Bangladesh.

Denmark's prime minister, Mette Frederiksen, called a parliamentary election to be held on March 24th. Support for Ms Frederiksen surged after she stood up to Mr Trump's recent threats to annex Greenland, an autonomous Danish territory. Still, concerns over the economy and her government's efforts to boost defence spending could weigh on support for her Social Democratic Party.

Figure of the day: 460,000, the number of graduates produced each year by China's elite "985" group of universities. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Clintons' date with Congress

Bill and Hillary Clinton are headed to Capitol Hill. After months of stalling, the Clintons will answer a congressional committee's questions about their ties to Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender. Mrs Clinton, who was Barack Obama's secretary of state, will testify in a closed-door deposition on Thursday. When Mr Clinton follows on Friday, he will become the first former president to testify before a congressional panel since 1983.

Neither has been accused of wrongdoing by Epstein's victims—and they deny any knowledge of his misdeeds. The Clintons' lawyer claims that the committee, which is led by Republicans, is creating "a public spectacle for partisan purposes". Mrs Clinton accuses the Justice Department of "slow-walking" the release of files related to Epstein; she maintains that the Trump administration is engaged in a "cover-up". Expect finger-pointing from all sides, but few revelations.

Photograph: Getty Images

Last chance for America and Iran

The window for diplomacy is closing. Officials from America and Iran will meet in Geneva on Thursday for a third round of negotiations aimed at preventing a war. The meeting comes as a second American aircraft-carrier is deployed near the Middle East. Satellite images show that many of the American warships usually docked in Bahrain are now out at sea. Donald Trump has promised to attack Iran if it does not negotiate a deal—though his objectives remain unclear.

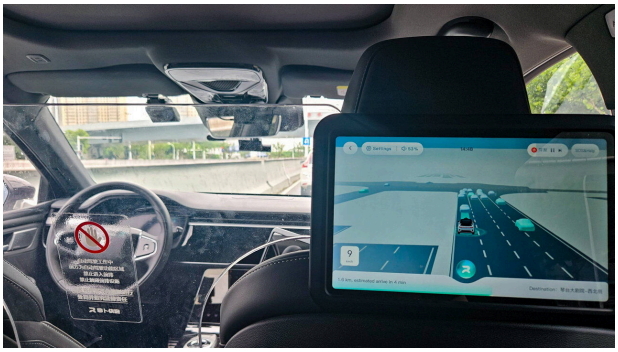
Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, will probably offer concessions on the country's uranium-enrichment programme. Some of Mr Trump's Republican allies want to avoid a deal that boosts Iran's embattled regime. So does Israel. Mr Trump made scant mention of Iran during his state-of-the-union address this week. He said Iran could avoid conflict if it promised not to build a bomb. But Iranian officials have offered similar assurances in the past; repackaging old rhetoric would hardly represent a breakthrough.

Illustration: David Simonds

A test in Manchester for Britain's government

Manchester will be the talk of Westminster on Thursday. Residents of Gorton and Denton, in the city's south-east, are voting to replace Andrew Gwynne, a Labour MP who resigned in January. It should be a safe Labour seat. The constituency had the 38th-largest Labour majority in 2024. Gorton, part of inner Manchester, has a young population and a large group of Muslim voters. Denton, a suburb, is mainly white and working class.

Yet the Labour government's unpopularity opens up opportunities for rivals. Reform UK and the Green Party are pouring resources into the constituency. Opinion polls indicate that all three parties stand a chance. The by-election is especially risky for the prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, who prevented Andy Burnham, the Greater Manchester mayor and a potential rival to lead the party, from standing as the Labour candidate. A Labour loss in Gorton and Denton would be bad for Sir Keir; a victory by Mr Burnham might have threatened him more.



Photograph: IMAGO

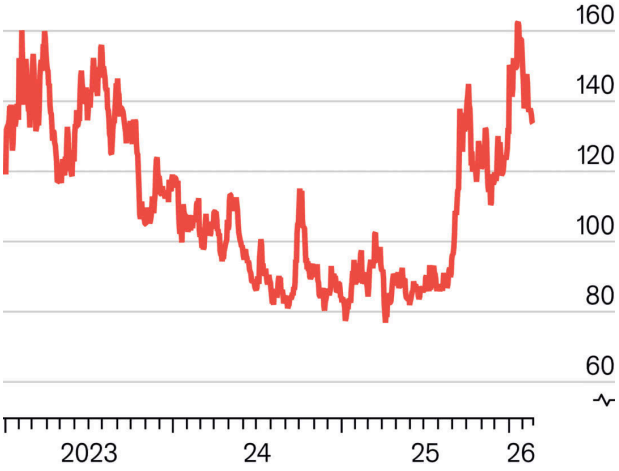
Baidu takes the wheel

Baidu, a Chinese search-engine giant, has a bad reputation at home. Many young Chinese blame it for turning the national internet into an ad-clogged cesspool. They ridicule its apps, which they say are unusable. Although Baidu was the first company to release a Chinese large language model for consumer use, called Ernie, it lags behind those created by competitors such as Alibaba, Tencent and ByteDance, the owner of TikTok.

Yet the picture is not entirely bleak. Baidu's driverless-taxi service, Apollo Go, has been pushing aggressively into foreign countries, most recently Dubai (in partnership with Uber, an American ride-hailing firm). It is also eyeing launches in Britain and Germany (with Lyft, another ride-hailing app) this year. When Baidu reports its full-year results on Thursday, investors will look for signs that China's search-engine titan is now a robotaxi champion-in-waiting.

Picking up speed

Baidu, share price, $



Source: LSEG Workspace

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

Wednesday: The third Monday of January is a federal holiday named after which civil-rights activist?

Success is having to worry about every damn thing in the world, except money.

Johnny Cash